
DARED - 2025 Annual Report

Direct Action for Rights and Equity Development

2025 ANNUAL REPORT

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Bringing Change and Development, One Community at a Time

Direct Action for Rights Equity and Development NGO is a registered as a nonprofit in Cameroon

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Introduction

The year 2025 was a fantastic year for Direct Action for Rights Equity and Development (DARED) as it strived to provide community based services, in spite of funding difficulties, security challenges and other challenges. This report summarizes the organization's achievement following the achievements and plans emanating from the 2024 narrative report.

DEH'S Vision and Achievements for 2024

The key areas envisaged for Direct Action for Rights Equity and Development (DARED) in 2024 can be summarized as follows:

1. 250 youths were engaged through the WHV campaign in heritage preservation
2. Engage in policy development in young participation in heritage protection and the effects of climate change in MADEX 2025 in Madagascar
3. 50 children engaged in summer bootcamp in training in arts and craft, music, web development
4. Storytelling as a tool for heritage preservation in Bafut community, Documenting of the story of the Founder of the Bafut Village
5. Environmental actions including tracing and clearing of trees planted in 2024 and planting of over 200 trees in the Bafut Royal Palace
6. Organization of cleanup campaign in a local market
7. Purification and treatment of artifacts at the Bafut Royal Museum and training of 30 young people of artifact treatment
8. Engaging over 800 youths (male and female) in Bamenda from the grass field and Fulani community in Bamenda through football as a tool for social cohesion
9. Engage over 30 persons with disability in football activity in promoting participation social cohesion
10. Engage the University of Bamenda, Faculty of international Heritage in the Bamendankwe Royal Palace and museum, visiting with over 30 students

1. 250 youths were engaged through the WHV campaign in heritage preservation

As part of the hands-on community engagement activities under the **Heritage Volunteer Project**, a dedicated team of **250 international, national and local volunteers** was successfully deployed at the historic **Bafut Royal Palace** for an intensive **12-day working period**.

Throughout this impactful initiative, the volunteers collaborated closely with local guides and craftsmen to carry out critical preservation tasks aimed at safeguarding the cultural legacy of the UNESCO tentative world heritage site.

Key Activities Completed

- **Environmental Conservation:** Planted native trees to combat soil erosion and beautify the palace ecosystem.
- **Site Maintenance:** Conducted comprehensive cleaning and debris removal across the expansive palace grounds and sacred shrines.
- **Museum Restoration:** Applied fresh coats of paint to the **Bafut Royal Museum**, rejuvenating the exhibition space that houses centuries-old royal artifacts.
- **Technical Excursion:** Undertook an educational site visit to the **College of Technology (COLTECH)** in Bafut to study the specialized, sustainable building materials manufactured locally for the ongoing structural restoration of the palace.

Project Outcomes and Community Impact

This collaborative effort not only revitalized the physical infrastructure of the kingdom but also fostered deep cultural exchange between the youth volunteers and the local population. At the conclusion of the 12-day exercise, the **Bafut traditional council and community members** expressed their profound appreciation to the project team. They commended the volunteers' unwavering commitment, energy, and respect for local traditions in helping to preserve and promote the tangible and intangible heritage of the Bafut Kingdom for future generations





2. International Capacity Building and Policy Advocacy: The I.V.Y. Africa - MadEx Framework

In line with DARED's strategic objective to influence heritage preservation policies through youth leadership and climate-resilient frameworks, a senior delegation represented the organization at the **International Volunteer Youth (I.V.Y.) Africa - MadEx Workshop**. Held in **Antananarivo, Madagascar**, the high-level convention was organized and hosted by the **Malagasy National Commission for UNESCO (COMMAT)**.

The workshop served as a critical platform for analyzing the intersection of youth volunteerism, sustainable development, and global climate action policy. It brought together civil society organizations and youth leaders from **over 15 African nations**, alongside international delegates from **China, Thailand, Germany, and Romania**, to co-create inclusive models for heritage protection.

Strategic Pillar Interventions & Field Methodology

- **Climate-Heritage Nexus Policy:** Developed policy-oriented strategies focusing on the escalating threats of climate change to tangible African heritage, resulting in actionable frameworks for designing resilient, community-led volunteer preservation models.
- **Participatory Action Research (PAR):** Field-tested community assessment methodologies at the **Royal Hill of Ambohimanga**, a UNESCO World Heritage site. Delegates engaged directly with indigenous communities and local institutional authorities to map structural, socio-economic, and environmental risks affecting the site.
- **Institutional Capacity and Advocacy:** Acquired and shared standardized toolkits for strategic project management, international fundraising diversification, and policy advocacy. These tools aim to structurally upscale youth-led initiatives within national heritage planning.

Policy Outcomes and Transnational Co-Creation

A primary deliverable of the workshop was the collaborative drafting of the **Global Youth Exchange Road Map**. This policy document outlines optimized protocols for regional and cross-continental youth mobilization, standardizing how civil society supports national heritage preservation agendas. DARED's active participation firmly anchors our local interventions within international best practices, ensuring our policy recommendations to national actors remain innovative and globally aligned.

Institutional Acknowledgments

DARED extends its formal gratitude to **UNESCO Madagascar** for their institutional hospitality and organizational leadership. Special recognition is due to **Ines Yousfi (UNESCO)** and **Mr. Francesco (Better World)** for their visionary facilitation and commitment to integrating youth dynamics into global heritage policy frameworks.



3. Socio-Cultural and Digital Empowerment: Children's Holiday Bootcamp

Project Overview and Strategic Partnerships

During the reporting period, **Direct Actions for Rights, Equity & Development (DARED)** successfully implemented the **Children's Holiday Bootcamp**. The initiative was executed in strategic partnership with the **Regional Delegation of Arts & Culture**, aligning civil society efforts with institutional frameworks for youth development, cultural preservation, and digital literacy.

Program Objectives

The bootcamp was designed as a holistic intervention to achieve the following programmatic objectives:

- **Enhance Creative Expression:** Stimulate artistic innovation through structured training in arts, crafts, painting, and drawing.
- **Bridge the Digital Divide:** Equip young demographics with foundational technical capabilities in computer programming and web development.
- **Cultivate Artistic Talent:** Build foundational musical competencies and appreciation through technical vocal and instrumental training.
- **Foster Soft Skill Development:** Provide a secure, inclusive environment optimized for teamwork, confidence-building, and peer-to-peer innovation.

Curricular Interventions and Skills Acquisition

The training curriculum was delivered across five core thematic pillars, combining practical technical expertise with essential soft skill development:

Core Technical Disciplines

- **Arts & Crafts:** Participants utilized basic materials to engineer decorative and utilitarian items, strengthening design-thinking and spatial problem-solving capabilities.
- **Painting & Drawing:** Instruction focused on advanced sketching, color theory, and shading techniques, improving focus, patience, and visual communication.
- **Computer Programming:** Facilitators introduced introductory coding logic and computational thinking to strengthen early-stage digital literacy.
- **Web Development:** Youth learned the mechanics of building functional, basic web pages, expanding content creation and digital interface skills.
- **Music Training:** Training covered basic music theory, rhythmic synchronization, and vocal dynamics, building collective performance capabilities.

Cross-Cutting Soft Skills

Parallel to the technical tracks, the bootcamp integrated modules to enhance:

- Collaborative teamwork and conflict resolution.
- Public speaking, presentation design, and verbal articulation.
- Personal agency, self-discipline, and emotional intelligence.

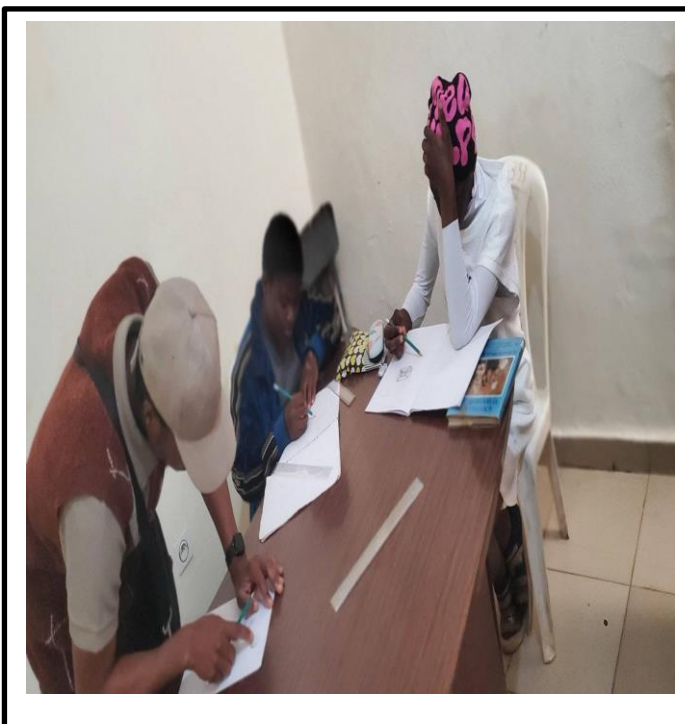
Demographics and Participation Metrics

The program successfully mobilized a diverse cohort of **50 children and adolescents**. Attendance and retention rates remained high throughout the duration of the camp, with all participants meeting the project's baseline performance indicators.

Institutional Closing and Evaluation Ceremony

The project concluded with a formal evaluation and closing ceremony attended by parents, community stakeholders, and institutional facilitators. High-level milestones from the ceremony included:

- **Certification:** Presentation of official Certificates of Participation to all 50 graduates.
- **Project Exhibition:** Public showcases featuring participant-led art exhibitions, live demonstrations of web applications, and collaborative musical performances.
- **Stakeholder Engagement:** Commendations and policy-aligned closing addresses delivered by ministry partners and technical facilitators, reinforcing the necessity of sustained non-formal education frameworks.





4. Environmental actions including tracing and clearing of trees planted in 2024 and planting of over 200 trees in the Bafut Royal Palace

Tree Planting Activity at the Bafut Royal Palace

Direct Action for Rights Equity and Development (DARED), with funding support from the North West Regional Assembly and in partnership with the Bafut Council and the UNESCO Heritage Volunteer Program 2025, successfully carried out a large-scale tree-planting initiative at the Bafut Royal Palace.

The activity focused on restoring the ecological balance of the palace environment and strengthening the cultural and economic heritage of the Bafut Kingdom. A total of 500 palm trees were planted around the palace grounds. This effort responds to the growing challenge of deforestation, which continues to threaten biodiversity, soil quality, and the traditional landscapes surrounding the palace.

Beyond environmental restoration, the initiative also promotes traditional economic sustainability, particularly through revitalizing the long-standing practice of palm wine tapping—a culturally significant and economically valuable activity within Bafut communities. By planting palm trees, the project supports future livelihoods while preserving an integral part of local identity.

This collaborative effort between community institutions and cultural heritage partners marks an important step in safeguarding both the natural environment and the cultural traditions of the Bafut Kingdom for generations to come.





5. Engaging over 800 youths (male and female) in Bamenda from the grass field and Fulani community in Bamenda through football as a tool for social cohesion

Year One Project Implementation Report

Football for Social Cohesion and Community Development Project

Implementing Partners

Development for Humanity (DEH), in partnership with DARED, successfully implemented the first year of the Football for Social Cohesion and Community Development Project in Bamenda, Northwest Region of Cameroon.

Project Overview

The project was designed to strengthen social cohesion among young people from the Grassfield majority and Fulani minority communities through football activities, while promoting environmental responsibility through community clean-up campaigns. The initiative also sought to foster inclusion of women and persons with disabilities and contribute to peaceful coexistence within communities affected by conflict.

Participant Engagement

During the implementation period, the project successfully engaged 865 direct participants, exceeding the initial participation targets. Women and girls represented 54% of all participants, demonstrating the project's strong commitment to gender inclusion and women's participation in community development and sports activities.

The project implemented male and female football activities, peace-building engagements, and community service initiatives that encouraged interaction among participants from diverse cultural and social backgrounds. These activities created opportunities for dialogue, teamwork, and mutual understanding among young people.

Despite extensive outreach and mobilization efforts, the project was unable to secure participation for the female amputee category. While male participants with disabilities were engaged, no eligible female amputee teams or participants could be identified within the project catchment area during the implementation period. The project team continues to explore partnerships with disability-focused organizations to improve inclusion in future phases.

Community Clean-Up Campaigns

A major highlight of the project was the successful implementation of community clean-up campaigns across selected communities in Bamenda. Through these activities, more than 1,000 young people and community members were engaged in environmental sanitation exercises.

Participants worked together to clean streets, public spaces, markets, drainage systems, and community facilities. Beyond improving environmental conditions, these activities strengthened relationships among participants and promoted a shared sense of responsibility for community wellbeing.

Key Achievements

Engaged 865 participants in football, peacebuilding, and community development activities

Achieved 54% female participation, surpassing gender inclusion expectations

Engaged over 1,000 youths and community members in community clean-up campaigns

Promoted peaceful interaction and collaboration between youths from different ethnic and cultural backgrounds

Strengthened community ownership of environmental protection and public sanitation initiatives

Fostered teamwork, leadership, and social cohesion through football-based interventions

Challenges

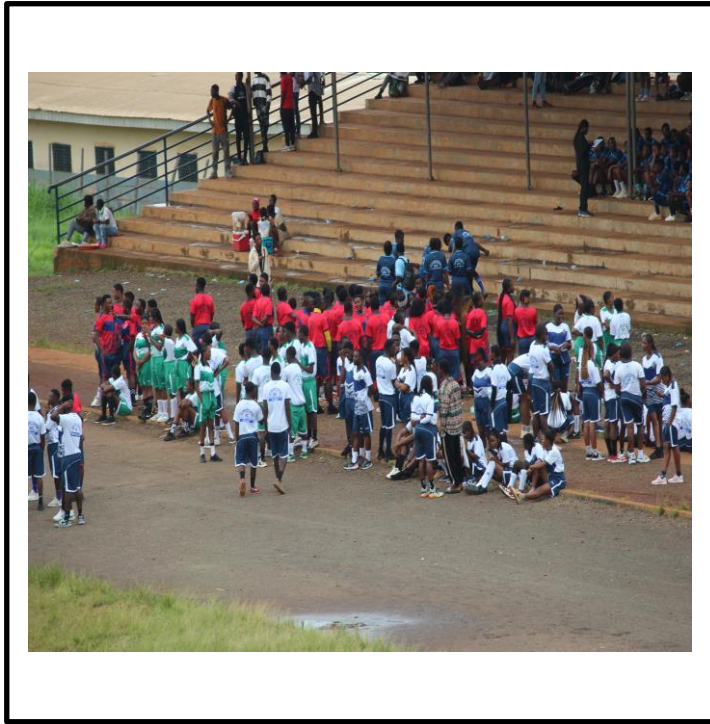
The primary challenge encountered was the inability to identify and recruit female amputee participants despite targeted mobilization efforts. This limited the implementation of the planned female amputee football activities. Future implementation will focus on strengthening partnerships with disability associations and rehabilitation centres to improve outreach and participation.

Conclusion and Future Outlook

The first year of the project demonstrated the power of football and community service as tools for social cohesion, inclusion, and community development. The strong participation levels, particularly among women and girls, and the successful engagement of over 1,000 youths in environmental action activities highlight the project's relevance and impact.

Building on these achievements, DEH and DARED look forward to the second year of implementation, with a focus on expanding participation, strengthening inclusion of persons with disabilities, deepening community engagement, and consolidating the gains made in promoting peaceful coexistence and sustainable community development across Bamenda.





6. Storytelling as a tool for heritage preservation in Bafut community, Documenting of the story of the Founder of the Bafut Village

In alignment with the **2003 UNESCO Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage**, DARED deployed **structured storytelling as a formal preservation mechanism** within the Bafut Royal Kingdom. Recognizing that oral histories face critical risks of attrition due to modernization and the passing of community elders, this targeted documentation initiative focused on recording, cataloging, and digitizing the foundational narrative of the **founding ancestor of Bafut**. The project team worked in close coordination with the *Fon* (traditional ruler), court historians, and local custodians of truth to ensure absolute cultural accuracy, transforming passive folklore into a validated historical record.

Rather than treating oral history as isolated memory, the project utilized storytelling to bridge the gap between intangible narratives and tangible landscapes. Documenting the founder's migration paths, early diplomatic alliances, and spiritual origins provided essential context to the sacred architecture and shrines within the **Bafut Royal Palace** (a UNESCO tentative world heritage site). Furthermore, the field methodology actively paired youth volunteers with community elders during the recording process, transforming data collection into a live venue for intergenerational knowledge transfer that renewed civic pride and cultural identity among the younger demographic.

By formalizing and synthesizing these oral allegories into standardized digital scripts, DARED has established a scalable baseline model for **Community-Based Inventorying**. This intervention demonstrates that the physical preservation of a heritage site is incomplete without protecting the intangible origin stories that give those structures meaning. The finalized

narrative now serves as a permanent educational and advocacy asset, reinforcing DARED's ongoing policy efforts to establish integrated heritage frameworks that treat tangible and intangible assets as a single, inseparable ecosystem.



Conclusion and Strategic Outlook

The year 2025 stands as a testament to the resilience, adaptability, and unwavering commitment of Direct Actions for Rights, Equity & Development (DARED). In spite of navigating complex funding environments, persistent security hurdles, and localized operational challenges, the organization successfully executed its core community-based interventions. From mobilising youth to preserve the tangible ecosystems of the Bafut Royal Palace to bridging the digital divide for children, DARED has

consistently translated its strategic vision into tangible community metrics. Furthermore, our active participation in global policy arenas like the I.V.Y. Africa - MadEx Workshop ensures that our grassroots methods remain firmly anchored in international best practices.

Moving into the next reporting cycle, DARED aims to consolidate these operational gains by expanding its multi-stakeholder partnerships. A key strategic priority will involve deepening our collaboration with institutional partners, regional delegations, and disability-focused organizations to systematically lower barriers to inclusion. Additionally, the organization will focus on scaling up its digital oral history archiving and community-based inventorying models to influence broader national heritage preservation policies. By combining environmental sustainability, socio-cultural empowerment, and targeted policy advocacy, DARED enters 2026 fully equipped to drive systemic, sustainable development—one community at a time.

Signed

TAMFU KILEM BONGWA

DIRECTOR

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read 'Tamfu Kilem Bongwa', is written over several horizontal lines. The signature is stylized with a large, looped 'T' and a long, sweeping horizontal stroke at the end.